

CHAPTER FIVE

Label & Author

In the fifth week of seventh grade, Mr. Patel handed Maya back a math quiz with a C-minus on it.

Maya was not in Mr. Patel's math class. Mr. Patel did not teach math. But Mr. Patel had been the teacher Maya had asked, in fifth grade, to look over her math homework when she was stuck — Mr. Patel had been good at it then, and the habit had carried — and so when Maya, last week, had walked into Room 36 during eighth-period free block looking distressed, Mr. Patel had said *Maya. Sit down. Show me.*

Maya had sat down.

She had taken the quiz out of her bag and put it on his desk. The quiz had a C-minus on it in red pen, with the teacher's note: *Maya — this is below your usual work. Office hours Tuesday if you want.*

Maya, looking at the quiz, had said quietly, *Mr. Patel. I think I am — I think I am losing it.*

Mr. Patel had said, *Maya. Sit down. Tell me what is going on.*

Maya had told him. The telling had taken a while.



Two years ago, in fifth grade, somebody at Lincoln Park Elementary had decided Maya was *the smart one*.

This had been meant kindly. It had been a label given to her by a previous teacher — not Mr. Patel — who had said it in

front of other teachers, who had mentioned it to Maya's parents at the conferences, who had said it back to Maya at the dinner table. Mrs. Phillips says *you are the smart one in the class, isn't that wonderful?* Maya, at ten years old, had said *thanks* and put her fork down and felt something she did not have a word for yet, which was the feeling of a label being lowered onto her shoulders like a heavy coat she had not asked for and did not know how to take off.

The Smart One.

For a year that label had been great. It had been great until the first time Maya did not understand something in class — and instead of just being a kid who did not understand something, which is what every other kid was, on a rotating schedule — she was *the smart one not understanding something*, which is a different kind of failure entirely. The label had made every wrong answer worse. The label had made every B feel like an F. The label, which had been designed as a compliment, had quietly become a cage.

By sixth grade, Maya was studying not to learn but to defend. By seventh grade, she had a stomachache before every test. And by this past Tuesday, when the seventh-grade math teacher handed back the quiz with the C-minus on it, the voice in Maya's head — the voice she had been hearing more and more lately, the voice that showed up to comment on every mistake — had said the thing it had been waiting to say since fifth grade:

If you are not the smart one, what are you?

She had told Mr. Patel this — not in those exact words, but close.

Mr. Patel had listened.

When she was done, Mr. Patel had said, *Maya. I want to draw something on a piece of paper for you. Can I?*

Maya had said yes.

Mr. Patel had taken a piece of paper. He had drawn a vertical line down the middle. He had written, on the left side, **LABEL**. On the right side, he had written **AUTHOR**.

He had said:

Maya. There is a difference between Label and Author. A label is what someone else writes on you, often before you can read. The smart one. The funny one. The athletic one. The shy one. The pretty one. The good one. You did not pick any of those. They were picked for you, by people who looked at you and made a guess and said the guess out loud. The label feels like a gift. The label is actually a prediction — a short, lazy, shorthand summary of who someone thinks you are based on a tiny slice of evidence — and when the prediction stops matching the data, you are the one who has to do the work of either living up to it or shedding it. Both are exhausting. One of them is actually possible.

He had paused.

The other side of the line is Author. The Author is who you say you are, written in your own hand, after you have thought about it. The Author is the thing you build for yourself, slowly, across years, as you figure out which of the labels were accurate and which were not, and which were yours to keep and which were yours to drop. The Author is the version of you that is being written by you, on purpose, in real time.

He had handed Maya the paper.

He had said:

Maya. The label that was put on you in fifth grade was the smart one. I do not know if you are the smart one. I do not actually have a way of measuring that, and neither did Mrs. Phillips. What I know is — you are a person who reads carefully, who pays attention to small things in stories that other kids

miss, who asks the kind of question after a chapter that makes me think about the chapter differently. I have known you since you were six. I have watched you read. I would not, if I were going to label you, label you the smart one. I would label you the careful reader. That is a different label. That is the label that fits your actual data.

But here is the thing. I do not get to label you either. Mrs. Phillips did not get to label you. You get to label you. That is what an Author is. The Author is the kid in seventh grade who looks at the label on the coat she has been wearing for two years and says this is not actually my coat. I am going to put it down. I am going to write a different label, in my own hand, on the inside of a coat I am going to grow into.

Maya had stared at the paper.

She had said, Mr. Patel. What if I cannot write a label yet?

Mr. Patel had said, Maya. Then you do not write one yet. You take off the old label, and you walk around with nothing on, and you wait. The waiting is part of it. The Author does not need to know the answer in seventh grade. The Author needs to know that the question is now hers to answer. That is — for now — the whole thing.

Maya had said okay.

Mr. Patel had said, Maya. One more thing.

Yes.

The C-minus. The math quiz. I want you to do something with it. Are you willing?

Yes.

I want you to write a card and put it on the Wall. The card can say whatever you want. I am not telling you what to write. I am suggesting that the C-minus is — in the deepest sense — a normal mistake, and the Wall is exactly the place for it. Most of

the cards on the Wall are about normal mistakes. The C-minus, on the Wall, will join its siblings.

She had thought about it.

She had said, Mr. Patel. *I do not want to sign it.*

He had said, *that is fine. Most of the cards are not signed. The Wall is yours to use however helps. Unsigned counts.*

She had said *okay.*

She had walked out of Room 36 with the paper Mr. Patel had drawn — the LABEL / AUTHOR paper — folded in her bag.

She had walked to the Wall.

She had picked up a card. She had written:

C-minus on the math quiz. I have been telling myself this is who I am now. It is just a math quiz.

She had pinned it up. She had stood for a second. She had walked to her locker.



This is what Label-and-Author looks like in seventh grade.

It does not look like a sudden self-reinvention. It does not look like *I am no longer the smart one, I am now the cool one.* That is just trading one label for another, which is not the work. The label is the genre. The label is the kind of thing the Author writes. Trading labels is not authoring; trading labels is just shopping.

Authoring looks like putting down the label, for a while, with nothing in its place, and being in the world without the label for some period of time, and seeing what shows up in the silence.

In Maya's case, what is going to show up in the silence — over the course of seventh grade — is that Maya is, in fact, an artist. Maya has been drawing since she was four. Maya has been drawing seriously since the basement studio her

grandmother let her set up in fourth grade. Maya, in seventh grade, has not yet thought of herself as an artist. She has thought of herself as the smart one who draws on the side. The label has been in front of the actual data.

When Maya puts down the label, in the C-minus moment in Mr. Patel's room, she does not yet know what is going to come up to fill the space. Over the course of the year, what is going to come up is the drawing. By June, Maya is going to be carrying her sketchbook with her every day. Maya is going to be drawing during fifth-period study hall, every day. Maya is going to have, by June, a folder of forty sketches that she is going to show Ms. Calloway during the Tuesday lunch block, and Ms. Calloway is going to say Maya. *These are good. These are really good. Have you shown your parents?* And Maya is going to say no, not yet, *I have not figured out how.*

The figuring-out-how is the work of high school. The figuring-out-that-she-is-an-artist is the work of seventh grade.

That work begins in Mr. Patel's room on a Tuesday afternoon, with a piece of paper that has a line down the middle and the words LABEL and AUTHOR on either side.

The paper is still in Maya's bag in June. Folded smaller than it started. A little worn at the edges. She takes it out sometimes, in private, when she is having a hard week.

That is what tools are for.



A note, to the kids reading this.

You have labels. Everyone does. *The smart one. The pretty one. The funny one. The lazy one. The dramatic one. The good one. The bad one. The forgotten one.* You did not pick any of

these. They were applied. You have been wearing them, in some cases, for years.

The labels are not necessarily wrong. Some of them are reasonably accurate. The kid who is good at math might, in fact, be good at math. But the label is not the whole truth. The label is a guess. The label is somebody else's first take, said out loud, and now you are walking around inside it.

You are old enough now to take off the labels, one at a time, and look at them.

Some of them you might keep. *The good listener* might fit. You might decide, after looking, that the good-listener label is one you want to keep wearing. That is fine.

Some of them you might put down. *The smart one* might not fit anymore. *The shy one* might not fit anymore. The data has changed. The label is from fifth grade. The Author who is writing now is in seventh.

Take them off, one at a time. Look at them.

The Author is whoever you are when the labels are on the floor.

You will not, at twelve, know the full answer to who is the Author. That is fine. The Author does not have to know the answer at twelve. The Author has to know that the question is hers.

That is enough for now.

Take off the labels. See what is underneath. Write the new ones in your own hand, in pencil, on the inside of a coat you are still growing into.

That is what seventh grade is for.

— J.A.R.